Harrowmere Borough Council

Invitation to Tender: Facilities Maintenance and Cleaning Services 2027 to 2031

This document is a fictional tender written to test document-analysis software. Harrowmere Borough Council, its sites and every figure in it are invented.

Tender reference: HBC/FM/2026/014

1. Introduction and background

Harrowmere Borough Council (the Council) is responsible for a mixed estate of civic offices, libraries, leisure centres, depots and community buildings spread across the borough. The estate has grown piecemeal over forty years, and the buildings vary widely in age, construction and condition. Some are listed, several were refurbished within the last decade, and two are scheduled for disposal during the life of this contract.

The Council currently buys planned maintenance, reactive repairs and daily cleaning under three separate agreements. Those agreements expire on 31 March 2027. Members have decided to combine them into one contract so that a single provider is accountable for the condition and cleanliness of each building, and so that the Council's small property team can manage one relationship in place of three.

The incumbent providers together employ 46 staff on the existing agreements, of whom 31 work mainly on cleaning. The Council spent approximately £1,850,000 on these services in the last financial year. These figures are given for information only and are not a commitment to any level of spend under the new contract.

All correspondence about this procurement must quote the tender reference HBC/FM/2026/014 in the subject line. Messages that do not quote it may go unanswered.

The Council is committed to open and fair competition. Nothing in this document should be read as favouring any existing supplier, and information that the incumbents hold by virtue of their current role has been included in the data room so that all tenderers start from the same position.

2. Procurement timetable

The Council intends to follow the timetable set out in this section. It reserves the right to change any date, and will tell all registered tenderers through the portal if it does so. Tenderers should check the portal regularly, since the Council will not chase individual organisations.

Clarification questions must be submitted through the portal by 17:00 on 6 November 2026. Questions received after that time will not be answered.

A site visit will take place on 3 November 2026, starting at 10:00 at the Civic Centre reception. Attendance at the site visit is mandatory, and a tender from an organisation that did not attend will be rejected.

Each tenderer may send no more than three representatives to the site visit and must register their names by 30 October 2026.

An optional online briefing will be held on 22 October 2026. Tenderers are encouraged to join, but nothing said at the briefing changes this document, and those who do not attend will not be disadvantaged.

Tenders must be received through the portal no later than 12:00 noon on 27 November 2026. The portal closes automatically at that time and late tenders cannot be accepted under any circumstances.

Tenders must remain open for acceptance for 120 days from the submission deadline.

The Council expects to notify tenderers of the outcome in January 2027 and to observe the standstill period before entering into the contract. Mobilisation is planned for February and March 2027, with services starting on 1 April 2027. The initial term is four years, with an option for the Council to extend by up to two further years.

3. Who may tender

The Council welcomes tenders from single organisations and from consortia. Small and medium-sized enterprises are encouraged to take part, whether on their own account or as a member of a group. Where a consortium tenders, the Council will contract with a single lead member who takes responsibility for the whole service.

The tenderer must show an annual turnover of at least £2,400,000 in each of its last three financial years, evidenced by audited accounts.

The tenderer shall hold, at the date of submission, all of the following accreditations: ISO 9001, ISO 14001, ISO 45001, SafeContractor, Gas Safe registration, NICEIC Approved Contractor status and BICSc corporate membership.

No more than two subcontractors may be used to deliver the services, and each must be named in the tender.

Tenderers must provide three references from contracts of a similar size delivered within the last five years, at least one of which must be from a public sector client.

The Council will carry out its own checks on financial standing using a credit reference agency. A poor score will not by itself lead to exclusion, but the Council may ask for further assurance. Organisations that have changed their name or structure in the last three years should explain the change so that the checks can be matched to the right entity.

Tenderers should be aware that the Council is subject to the Freedom of Information Act 2000. Information supplied in a tender may be disclosed on request unless an exemption applies. Tenderers who consider any part of their tender commercially sensitive should say so, and say why, although the Council alone decides whether to disclose.

4. Format of the tender

Evaluators read a large number of tenders in a short time. Clear, well-organised responses that answer the question asked are far more persuasive than long ones, and marketing material that

does not address a question will be ignored. The requirements in this section exist so that every tender can be read and compared on the same basis.

The tender must be uploaded as a single PDF file that does not exceed 40 MB.

4.3 The method statement shall not exceed 30 pages, including any diagrams and appendices.

Text must be set in Arial at no less than 11 point, and the tender must be written in English.

All prices shall be stated in pounds sterling and shall exclude VAT.

Prices must be held firm for the first 24 months of the contract. After that they may be adjusted once a year in line with the Consumer Prices Index.

The pricing schedule is provided as a spreadsheet in the data room. Tenderers should complete every cell. A blank cell will be treated as a price of zero for that item, and the Council will hold the tenderer to it. Arithmetic errors will be corrected by taking the unit rate as correct and recalculating the total.

Tenderers may submit one variant tender in addition to a fully compliant one, provided the variant is clearly labelled. A variant will only be considered if the compliant tender from the same organisation has passed every stage of evaluation.

5. Financial security and insurance

The Council has to protect public money against the failure of a provider part-way through the term. The securities in this section are set at levels that the Council's finance team considers proportionate to the size of the contract, and they are not open to negotiation after award.

Each tender must be accompanied by a bid bond of £25,000, issued by a bank authorised by the Prudential Regulation Authority.

The successful tenderer shall provide a performance bond equal to 10% of the annual contract value within 14 days of the award letter.

The contractor shall maintain public liability insurance of not less than £10,000,000 for any one claim, employer's liability insurance of not less than £5,000,000 and professional indemnity insurance of not less than £2,000,000.

Where the tenderer is a subsidiary, a parent company guarantee in the form set out in the data room must be provided before the contract is signed.

Certificates of insurance will be requested from the preferred tenderer only. Tenderers do not need to hold the stated levels of cover when they submit, but they must confirm in the Form of Tender that the cover will be in place by the start date. The Council may ask to see renewal certificates each year.

The Council pays undisputed invoices within 30 days of receipt and expects its contractor to pay its own supply chain on the same terms. Payment performance will be reviewed at quarterly contract meetings.

6. People

The quality of this service depends on the people who deliver it. Many of the staff who currently clean and maintain the Council's buildings have done so for years and know the sites well. The Council wants a provider that will keep that knowledge, invest in training, and treat its workforce fairly.

The Council's view is that the Transfer of Undertakings (Protection of Employment) Regulations 2006 are likely to apply to this contract. Tenderers must take their own advice. Anonymised workforce information supplied by the incumbents is in the data room, and the Council gives no warranty that it is complete or accurate.

Every member of staff who works in a library, leisure centre or community building shall hold an enhanced DBS certificate issued within the previous three years.

All staff engaged on the contract must be paid at least the Real Living Wage from the first day of service.

The contractor shall appoint a full-time contract manager with a minimum of five years of experience in managing facilities contracts of comparable value.

At least 4 apprenticeships must be created during the initial term, each lasting no less than twelve months.

The Council would welcome proposals for recruiting from within the borough, and for working with local colleges, but these are not requirements and tenderers will not be marked down for proposing a different approach to social value.

7. Service standards

The full specification is in the data room and runs to some two hundred pages. This section draws out the standards that matter most to building users. Where this section and the full specification differ, this section takes precedence.

Emergency repairs must be attended within 2 hours of the call being logged, urgent repairs within 24 hours, and routine repairs within 5 working days.

The contractor shall operate a helpdesk that answers calls 24 hours a day on every day of the year.

A performance report must be delivered to the Council by the fifth working day of each month.

Cleaning audits shall achieve a score of at least 98% at every site in every month.

All cleaning chemicals used on the contract must carry the EU Ecolabel or an equivalent certification.

The Council has declared a climate emergency and aims to be carbon neutral across its own operations by 2035. It expects the contractor to support that aim, for example by moving to electric vehicles as leases fall due, but it has not set a date by which the contractor's fleet must be converted.

Building users report faults in many ways: by telephone, by email, in person to caretakers, and through the Council's own website. The contractor will need to bring those routes together so that every report is logged once, given a priority, and tracked through to completion.

8. How tenders will be evaluated

Tenders will be evaluated on the basis of the most advantageous tender, weighted 60% for quality and 40% for price. Social value accounts for 10 of the 60 quality points. The lowest compliant price will receive the full price score and other prices will be scored in proportion to it.

A tender that scores less than 50% of the available quality marks will be excluded, whatever its price.

Quality responses will be scored from 0 to 5 by a panel of at least three officers working independently, and the scores will then be moderated. The panel may invite the three highest-scoring tenderers to a clarification interview. Interviews are not scored separately, but may lead the panel to adjust its scores where a written answer is shown to be unclear.

The Council is not bound to accept the lowest or any tender, and will not reimburse any cost incurred in tendering. Abnormally low tenders will be investigated and may be rejected if the tenderer cannot explain the price to the Council's satisfaction.

9. Annex A: Sites in scope

The services shall be delivered at all of the following fourteen sites: Harrowmere Civic Centre, Eastgate Library, Quarry Lane Depot, Millbrook Leisure Centre, St Aldhelm's Community Hall, Northfield Library, the Old Corn Exchange, Wetherby Road Depot, Castle Park Pavilion, Fenwick House, the Registry Office, Lowmoor Leisure Centre, Bridge Street Customer Hub and Ashdown Cemetery Lodge.

Fenwick House and the Old Corn Exchange are listed buildings, and work there needs the prior consent of the Council's conservation officer. Quarry Lane Depot and Wetherby Road Depot are expected to be sold during the term, at which point they will leave the contract and the price will be adjusted using the rates in the pricing schedule.

Floor areas, opening hours and asset lists for each site are in the data room. The Council has taken care in preparing them but tenderers should satisfy themselves, at the site visit and otherwise, as to the extent of the work.

10. Annex B: Form of Tender

The Form of Tender must be completed in full, signed and included in the tender. A tender without a completed and signed Form of Tender is not valid.

Name of tenderer: .....

Company registration number: .....

Registered office address: .....

The bank issuing the bid bond shall be: .....

Total annual price in pounds sterling, excluding VAT: .....

Signed by an authorised signatory: ..... Date: .....

By signing, the tenderer confirms that it has read every clarification note issued through the portal, that the tender is its own work, and that it has not colluded with any other tenderer.

11. Clarification notes issued to date

Clarification Note 1, issued 14 October 2026. In response to a question, the Council confirms that the data room now contains condition surveys for all sites except Ashdown Cemetery Lodge, which will be surveyed in the spring.

Clarification Note 2, issued 16 October 2026. The page limit in paragraph 4.3 is increased from 30 pages to 35 pages. No other part of section 4 is changed.

Clarification Note 3, issued 19 October 2026. The Council has been asked whether electric vehicles are mandatory. They are not. See section 7.